

Policy Brief: Mukhyamantri Ladli Behna Yojana, Madhya Pradesh

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Abstract

“Mukhyamantri Ladli Behna Yojana (Ladli Bahna)” is a large-scale unconditional cash-transfer programme for adult women in Madhya Pradesh, launched in 28 January 2023 and expanded since then. It provides monthly DBT payments (recently raised – Oct 2025 to Rs 1,500 per beneficiary) to eligible women to improve household welfare, nutrition and women’s bargaining power. The programme reaches over 1.2 crore beneficiaries and now represents a major recurring fiscal commitment (≈Rs 22,000 crore/year after the latest increase). By emphasising its focus on women from the low-income groups in both rural and urban areas, the Scheme has taken steps towards accomplishing the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), particularly on gender equality, poverty alleviation & financial inclusion.

Background & Objectives-

Women- particularly from the marginalised sections of the society- face severe economic challenges, primarily due to their limited access to resources, brim employment prospects and weak social support networks. Factoring in their reliance on the male counterpart for financial support makes them the most vulnerable, as it restricts their capacity to make financial decisions on their own. The “**Ladli Behana**” Scheme was introduced in response to these persistent issues. By directly assisting women financially and encouraging their financial independence, consequently enhancing their social status. The Scheme aims to address gender based economic disparity.

The scheme provides regular cash assistance to women (married, widowed, divorced, abandoned, and certain frontline female workers) via Direct Benefit Transfer into Aadhaar- linked bank accounts. It was originally introduced at Rs.1,000/month in 2023 and progressively increased. The main objectives are to improve women’s economic autonomy, household nutrition, and strengthen women’s social status and decision-making power within families.

Key Features of the Scheme-

1. Women belonging to the Schedule Tribes (STs), Scheduled Castes (SCs) and other backward castes (OBCs)– groups that are prone to social and economic disadvantages – are among the marginalised communities and are given more priority under the Scheme.
 2. The Scheme incorporates Financial Literacy Training to improve the impact of the financial aid provided. These initiatives enable the recipients to prudently handle their finances and encourage well-informed spending and saving choices.
 3. **Monthly cash assistance:** Rs.1,500 per eligible woman (revised from Rs.1,250 from November 2025).
- **Beneficiaries:-** Approximately 1.26–1.27 crore women across all districts of Madhya Pradesh.

- **Mode of transfer:** Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) into Aadhaar-linked bank accounts.
- **Eligibility:-** Women aged 21–60 years, residents of Madhya Pradesh, non-government employees, with family annual income below Rs. 2.5 lakh.
- **Special top-up:** A Rs.250/ „**Bhai-Dooj Shagun**’ was credited in October 2025.

Latest Data and Financial Overview-

1. Total beneficiaries (as of Oct 2025): ~1.26 crore.
2. Latest installment (October 2025): Rs 1,541 crore credited to beneficiaries’ accounts.
3. Cumulative disbursement (since 2023): Over Rs 40,000 crore across multiple installments.
4. Annual expenditure projection (2025–26): Approximately Rs. 22,000 crore.
5. Verification drives and data audits are ongoing to ensure accurate targeting.

Quick Data Summary-

Sr No	Indicator	Latest Figure / Note	Source
1	Beneficiary count	~1.26–1.27 crore women (Oct 2025)	Media reports
2	Latest installment	Rs.1,541–Rs,1,551 crore (Oct 2025)	Govt/media
3	Current monthly benefit	Rs.1,500 from Nov 2025	Official announcement
4	Cumulative disbursed	Tens of thousands of crores since 2023	MP CM statements
5	Registration status	Verification ongoing, new enrolments paused	Govt
6	Beneficiary count	~1.26–1.27 crore women (Oct 2025)	Media reports

Notes: Based on multiple state press releases and national media coverage (Oct 2025). For official data, refer to MP Finance Department and scheme website.

Implementation Process-

The scheme operates through an extensive digital and administrative infrastructure:

1. Application and verification through local gram panchayats and urban bodies MunicipalCorprations .
2. Beneficiary list validation using Aadhaar and bank linkage.
3. Direct credit of funds into beneficiaries’ accounts on pre-announced dates.
4. Monitoring via district-level officers and online MIS dashboards.

Impact Analysis-

Preliminary assessments and survey data indicate that the “**Ladli Behna Yojana**” has increased household consumption, improved women’s control over expenditure, and enhanced their sense of economic security. According to SBI Research (2024), beneficiary households reported an average monthly spending increase of Rs.9,300.

The scheme has also contributed to financial inclusion by promoting bank account usage among women.

Key Challenges-

1. Fiscal sustainability: The recurring expenditure places a heavy burden on the state budget.
2. Targeting inefficiencies: Risk of inclusion of ineligible beneficiaries and exclusion of eligible poor women.
3. Administrative capacity: Ensuring real-time verification and grievance handling at scale.
4. Lack of complementary skill or livelihood programmes linked to the cash transfers.

Policy Recommendations-

1. Develop a 3-year fiscal sustainability roadmap to manage financial burden.
2. Introduce periodic verification and social audits to maintain beneficiary integrity.
3. Integrate cash transfers with optional skill development, microfinance, and livelihood programmes.
4. Establish a transparent, real-time data dashboard for public accountability.
5. Commission independent impact evaluations to assess long-term socio-economic outcomes.

Conclusion:-

The “Mukhyamantri Ladli Behna Yojana” has emerged as a transformative welfare programme for women in Madhya Pradesh. While its scale and coverage have provided significant socio-economic benefits, the sustainability and efficiency of the scheme depend on improved fiscal planning, better targeting, and integration with broader empowerment initiatives. With the right reforms, the scheme can serve as a model for gender-responsive governance across India.

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